SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE: LAWS, RULES, CONSCIENCE

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE — LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND — LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY — ETHICS IN MAKING RULES — CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION — CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept appropriate structure: the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

● PRIMARY CORE FLOW ● SUBORDINATE EXTRA ● APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g1 and all prior artifacts unchanged

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP

SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP · CENTRAL FOCUS · 1. SOURCES OF ETHICAL GUIDANCE MAP · [1] CONSCIENCE SIGNALS AN INTERNAL MORAL CONCERN. · [2] FAMILY AND SOCIAL LEARNING SHAPE EARLY MORAL JUDGMENT. · [3] PROFESSIONAL ETHICS ARTICULATE OCCUPATIONAL VALUES. · [4] CONDUCT CODES SPECIFY INSTITUTIONAL EXPECTATIONS. · [5] SERVICE RULES GOVERN DEFINED OFFICIAL CONDUCT.

CENTRAL FOCUS

1. Sources of ethical guidance map → [1] Conscience signals an internal moral concern. → [2] Family and social learning shape early moral judgment.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 1. Sources of ethical guidance map
- [1] Conscience signals an internal moral concern.
- [2] Family and social learning shape early moral judgment.

MECHANISM

- [3] Professional ethics articulate occupational values.
- [4] Conduct codes specify institutional expectations.
- [5] Service rules govern defined official conduct.
- [6] Regulations operate under delegated legal authority.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Statutes establish binding public legal standards.
- [8] Constitutional limits test all public authority.
- VERDICT → Treat the sources as interacting checks, not as a mechanical ladder that legalises every compliant act.
- ANSWER USE → Use for an opening definition map before resolving a law-rule-conscience conflict.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER USE → Use for an opening definition map before resolving a law-rule-conscience conflict.

01

STAGE 01

LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION

LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 2. LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND INSTRUCTION · [1] START WITH CONSTITUTIONAL COMPETENCE AND RIGHTS. · [2] IDENTIFY THE PARENT STATUTE AND ITS PURPOSE. · [3] LOCATE ANY DELEGATED RULE-MAKING POWER. · [4] CHECK WHETHER A VALID RULE APPLIES. · [5] IDENTIFY REGULATOR-MADE REGULATIONS, IF ANY.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 2. Law, rule, regulation and instruction → [1] Start with constitutional competence and rights. → [2] Identify the parent statute and its purpose. → [3] Locate any delegated rule-making power.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 2. Law, rule, regulation and instruction
- [1] Start with constitutional competence and rights.
- [2] Identify the parent statute and its purpose.

MECHANISM

- [3] Locate any delegated rule-making power.
- [4] Check whether a valid rule applies.
- [5] Identify regulator-made regulations, if any.
- [6] Separate circulars and guidelines from regulations.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Check service-rule or contractual adoption of codes.
- [8] Record the instrument's actual legal force.
- VERDICT → Never call every office instruction a law or every guideline delegated legislation.
- ANSWER USE → Use in the 2020 laws-versus-rules answer and in rule-of-law case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: ANSWER USE → Use in the 2020 laws-versus-rules answer and in rule-of-law case studies.

02

STAGE 02

LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY

LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY · CENTRAL FOCUS · 3. LEGALITY, ETHICS AND PROPRIETY · [1] ASK WHETHER THE ACTOR HAS LEGAL AUTHORITY. · [2] CHECK COMPLIANCE WITH APPLICABLE RULE AND PROCEDURE. · [3] IDENTIFY THE PUBLIC PURPOSE OF THE POWER. · [4] TEST FAIRNESS AND EQUAL TREATMENT. · [5] MAP FORESEEABLE HARMS AND BENEFITS.

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
CENTRAL FOCUS	[1] Identify the public purpose of the power.	[7] Assess trust and institutional precedent.
3. Legality, ethics and propriety	[4] Test fairness and equal treatment.	[8] State a qualified ethical-propriety verdict.
[1] Ask whether the actor has legal authority.	[5] Map foreseeable harms and benefits.	VERDICT — Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.
[2] Check compliance with applicable rule and procedure.	[6] Check conflicts, gifts and appearance of bias.	ANSWER USE — Use to structure a legal-but-unethical example without implying that ethics overrides law.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 3. Legality, ethics and propriety
- [1] Ask whether the actor has legal authority.
- [2] Check compliance with applicable rule and procedure.

MECHANISM

- [3] Identify the public purpose of the power.
- [4] Test fairness and equal treatment.
- [5] Map foreseeable harms and benefits.
- [6] Check conflicts, gifts and appearance of bias.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Assess trust and institutional precedent.
- [8] State a qualified ethical-propriety verdict.
- VERDICT — Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.
- ANSWER USE — Use to structure a legal-but-unethical example without implying that ethics overrides law.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Technical legality is necessary but does not exhaust ethics or propriety.

03

STAGE 03

ETHICS IN MAKING RULES

ETHICS IN MAKING RULES · CENTRAL FOCUS · 4. ETHICS IN MAKING RULES · [1] DEFINE THE LEGITIMATE PUBLIC OBJECTIVE. · [2] IDENTIFY AFFECTED GROUPS AND UNEQUAL BURDENS. · [3] CHOOSE AUTHORITY CONSISTENT WITH THE PARENT LAW. · [4] MAKE CRITERIA INTELLIGIBLE AND TRANSPARENT. · [5] TEST PROPORTIONALITY OF RESTRICTIONS AND SANCTIONS.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 4. Ethics in making rules → [1] Define the legitimate public objective. → [2] Identify affected groups and unequal burdens. → [3] Choose authority consistent with the parent law.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 4. Ethics in making rules
- [1] Define the legitimate public objective.
- [2] Identify affected groups and unequal burdens.

MECHANISM

- [3] Choose authority consistent with the parent law.
- [4] Make criteria intelligible and transparent.
- [5] Test proportionality of restrictions and sanctions.
- [6] Build access and accommodation where authorised.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Provide reasons, appeal and review mechanisms.
- [8] Revise after evidence of exclusion or harm.
- VERDICT — Ethics improves legitimacy, fairness and implementation; it does not create delegated power.
- ANSWER USE — Use for the second half of 2020 GS-IV Q4(a).

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Ethics improves legitimacy, fairness and implementation; it does not create delegated power.

04

STAGE 04

CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION

CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 5. CONSTITUTIONAL MORALITY IN ADMINISTRATION · [1] IDENTIFY THE CONSTITUTIONAL VALUE IN ISSUE. · [2] CHECK COMPETENCE AND LEGAL AUTHORITY. · [3] PROTECT EQUALITY AND NON-ARBITRARINESS. · [4] RESPECT DIGNITY AND AFFECTED-PERSON VOICE. · [5] FOLLOW DUE PROCESS AND FAIR HEARING.

CENTRAL FOCUS

5. Constitutional morality in administration → [1] Identify the constitutional value in issue. → [2] Check competence and legal authority.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 5. Constitutional morality in administration
- [1] Identify the constitutional value in issue.
- [2] Check competence and legal authority.

MECHANISM

- [3] Protect equality and non-arbitrariness.
- [4] Respect dignity and affected-person voice.
- [5] Follow due process and fair hearing.
- [6] Give intelligible public reasons.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Resist majoritarian or partisan pressure.
- [8] Accept competent review and correction.
- VERDICT — Constitutional morality disciplines both majority pressure and private preference.
- ANSWER USE — Use for the 2019 and 2025 constitutional-morality routes.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Constitutional morality disciplines both majority pressure and private preference.

05

STAGE 05

CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE

CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE · CENTRAL FOCUS · 6. CALIBRATING CONSCIENCE · [1] NOTICE THE MORAL ALARM OR DISCOMFORT. · [2] COLLECT FACTS INSTEAD OF ACTING ON IMPULSE. · [3] NAME THE AFFECTED STAKEHOLDERS AND HARMS. · [4] CHECK PERSONAL BIAS AND INCOMPLETE INFORMATION. · [5] IDENTIFY APPLICABLE LAW AND SERVICE RULES.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 6. Calibrating conscience → [1] Notice the moral alarm or discomfort. → [2] Collect facts instead of acting on impulse. → [3] Name the affected stakeholders and harms.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 6. Calibrating conscience
- [1] Notice the moral alarm or discomfort.
- [2] Collect facts instead of acting on impulse.

MECHANISM

- [3] Name the affected stakeholders and harms.
- [4] Check personal bias and incomplete information.
- [5] Identify applicable law and service rules.
- [6] Test constitutional values and public purpose.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Consult a competent institutional channel.
- [8] Record a revisable reasoned conclusion.
- VERDICT — Conscience is an ethical signal that becomes reliable through evidence and public reasoning.
- ANSWER USE — Use for 2023 GS-IV Q5(a) and conscience-based case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Conscience is an ethical signal that becomes reliable through evidence and public reasoning.

06

STAGE 06

CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER

CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER · CENTRAL FOCUS · 7. CRISIS OF CONSCIENCE RESPONSE LADDER · [1] DEFINE THE INSTRUCTION AND MORAL CONFLICT PRECISELY. · [2] VERIFY FACTS, LAW AND SERIOUSNESS OF HARM. · [3] REFLECT AND SEEK ETHICAL OR LEGAL CLARIFICATION. · [4] PLACE A FACTUAL WRITTEN OBJECTION ON RECORD. · [5] SEEK RECUSAL ONLY WHERE AUTHORITY PERMITS IT.

CENTRAL FOCUS

7. Crisis of conscience response ladder → [1] Define the instruction and moral conflict precisely. → [2] Verify facts, law and seriousness of harm.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 7. Crisis of conscience response ladder
- [1] Define the instruction and moral conflict precisely.
- [2] Verify facts, law and seriousness of harm.

MECHANISM

- [3] Reflect and seek ethical or legal clarification.
- [4] Place a factual written objection on record.
- [5] Seek recusal only where authority permits it.
- [6] Escalate to a competent superior or oversight body.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Report verified wrongdoing through available channels.
- [8] Consider resignation only after grave unresolved complicity.
- VERDICT — Use the lowest effective accountable channel, not silent compliance or immediate public defiance.
- ANSWER USE — Use in the 2019 crisis-of-conscience answer and public-service dilemmas.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Use the lowest effective accountable channel, not silent compliance or immediate public defiance.

07

STAGE 07

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT

CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT · CENTRAL FOCUS · 8. CIVIL DISOBEDIENCE VERSUS INSTITUTIONAL DISSENT · [1] CITIZEN IDENTIFIES AN UNJUST LAW OR POLICY. · [2] CIVIL RESISTANCE IS PUBLIC AND COMMUNICATIVE. · [3] NON-VIOLENCE LIMITS COERCIVE HARM. · [4] ACCEPTANCE OF CONSEQUENCE SIGNALS PRINCIPLED PROTEST. · [5] PUBLIC SERVANT HOLDS DELEGATED OFFICIAL AUTHORITY.

CORE CLAIM	MECHANISM	CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT
CENTRAL FOCUS	[3] Non-violence limits coercive harm.	[7] Dissent begins with review and escalation channels.
8. Civil disobedience versus institutional dissent	[4] Acceptance of consequence signals principled protest.	[8] External action needs necessity and proportionality.
[1] Citizen identifies an unjust law or policy.	[5] Public servant holds delegated official authority.	VERDICT — Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.
[2] Civil resistance is public and communicative.	[6] Office duty requires records and confidentiality.	ANSWER USE — Use to distinguish principled resistance from unaccountable disclosure.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 8. Civil disobedience versus institutional dissent
- [1] Citizen identifies an unjust law or policy.
- [2] Civil resistance is public and communicative.

MECHANISM

- [3] Non-violence limits coercive harm.
- [4] Acceptance of consequence signals principled protest.
- [5] Public servant holds delegated official authority.
- [6] Office duty requires records and confidentiality.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Dissent begins with review and escalation channels.
- [8] External action needs necessity and proportionality.
- VERDICT — Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.
- ANSWER USE — Use to distinguish principled resistance from unaccountable disclosure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Do not import the citizen's civil-disobedience model unchanged into public-service office duties.

08

STAGE 08

WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS

WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS · CENTRAL FOCUS · 9. WHISTLEBLOWING AND PROTECTED CHANNELS · [1] IDENTIFY EVIDENCE OF SERIOUS WRONGDOING OR HARM. · [2] SEPARATE FACT FROM POLICY DISAGREEMENT OR GRIEVANCE. · [3] PRESERVE MATERIAL LAWFULLY AND CONFIDENTIALLY. · [4] ASSESS IMMEDIATE PUBLIC-INTEREST URGENCY. · [5] USE THE LEAST COMPROMISED COMPETENT RECIPIENT.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 9. Whistleblowing and protected channels
- [1] Identify evidence of serious wrongdoing or harm.
- [2] Separate fact from policy disagreement or grievance.

MECHANISM

- [3] Preserve material lawfully and confidentially.
- [4] Assess immediate public-interest urgency.
- [5] Use the least compromised competent recipient.
- [6] Verify current protection and confidentiality scope.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Document retaliation risk and requested safeguard.
- [8] Seek independent review of response or inaction.
- VERDICT — Whistleblowing is evidence-based public-interest reporting, not an automatic entitlement to leak.
- ANSWER USE — Use for the 2022 protection route and conscience-to-accountability answers.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Whistleblowing is evidence-based public-interest reporting, not an automatic entitlement to leak.

09

STAGE 09

SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST

SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST · CENTRAL FOCUS · 10. SNOWDEN-TYPE EXTERNAL DISCLOSURE TEST · [1] SPECIFY THE ALLEGED PUBLIC WRONG. · [2] VERIFY EVIDENCE AND CREDIBILITY OF THE CONCERN. · [3] MAP PRIVACY, TRANSPARENCY AND SECURITY VALUES. · [4] ASSESS REALISTIC INTERNAL OVERSIGHT CHANNELS. · [5] TEST WHETHER THOSE CHANNELS ARE INADEQUATE.

CENTRAL FOCUS

10. Snowden-type external disclosure test → [1] Specify the alleged public wrong. → [2] Verify evidence and credibility of the concern.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 10. Snowden-type external disclosure test
- [1] Specify the alleged public wrong.
- [2] Verify evidence and credibility of the concern.

MECHANISM

- [3] Map privacy, transparency and security values.
- [4] Assess realistic internal oversight channels.
- [5] Test whether those channels are inadequate.
- [6] Consider narrower authorised disclosure alternatives.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Minimise avoidable harm to uninvolved persons.
- [8] Give a qualified necessity- proportionality verdict.
- VERDICT — A serious conscience claim strengthens only when method, necessity and proportionality also withstand scrutiny.
- ANSWER USE — Use for 2018 GS-IV Q12 without treating the question's legal claims as settled facts.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — A serious conscience claim strengthens only when method, necessity and proportionality also withstand scrutiny.

10

STAGE 10

FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION

FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION · CENTRAL FOCUS · 11. FORM, SUBSTANCE AND REASONED DISCRETION · [1] IDENTIFY THE STATUTORY OR SCHEME PURPOSE. · [2] READ THE APPLICABLE RULE AND ITS EXCEPTION. · [3] ESTABLISH RELEVANT FACTS AND AFFECTED INTERESTS. · [4] CHECK WHETHER EQUIVALENT COMPLIANCE IS AUTHORISED. · [5] TREAT SIMILARLY PLACED PERSONS ALIKE.

CENTRAL FOCUS

11. Form, substance and reasoned discretion → [1] Identify the statutory or scheme purpose. → [2] Read the applicable rule and its exception.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 11. Form, substance and reasoned discretion
- [1] Identify the statutory or scheme purpose.
- [2] Read the applicable rule and its exception.

MECHANISM

- [3] Establish relevant facts and affected interests.
- [4] Check whether equivalent compliance is authorised.
- [5] Treat similarly placed persons alike.
- [6] Reject ultra-vires or selective waiver.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Record authority, alternatives and reasons.
- [8] Enable audit, appeal and judicial review.
- VERDICT — Substance corrects mechanical literalism only within authority, equality and review safeguards.
- ANSWER USE — Use for 2024 Q4(b) and discretionary welfare or procurement cases.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — Substance corrects mechanical literalism only within authority, equality and review safeguards.

11

STAGE 11

ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS

ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS · CENTRAL FOCUS · 12. ANSWER-WRITING SYNTHESIS · [1] DEFINE THE PRECISE SOURCE-OF-GUIDANCE ISSUE. · [2] DISTINGUISH LAW, RULE, REGULATION AND CODE. · [3] IDENTIFY CONSTITUTIONAL VALUE AND LEGAL AUTHORITY. · [4] STATE THE ETHICAL HARM OR PUBLIC-INTEREST CONCERN. · [5] TEST CONSCIENCE AGAINST FACTS AND BIAS.

CENTRAL FOCUS → 12. Answer-writing synthesis → [1] Define the precise source-of-guidance issue. → [2] Distinguish law, rule, regulation and code. → [3] Identify constitutional value and legal authority.

CORE CLAIM

- CENTRAL FOCUS
- 12. Answer-writing synthesis
- [1] Define the precise source-of-guidance issue.
- [2] Distinguish law, rule, regulation and code.

MECHANISM

- [3] Identify constitutional value and legal authority.
- [4] State the ethical harm or public-interest concern.
- [5] Test conscience against facts and bias.
- [6] Choose institutional channel and safeguard.

CONSEQUENCE / LIMIT

- [7] Use a named Indian administrative illustration.
- [8] Conclude with a qualified accountable verdict.
- VERDICT — High-scoring answers combine ethical sensitivity with lawful, evidence-based institutional action.
- ANSWER USE — Use as the final revision checklist for theory questions and case studies.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: VERDICT — High-scoring answers combine ethical sensitivity with lawful, evidence-based institutional action.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT · 1. ARCHITECTURE · 2. CONCEPTS AND DISTINCTIONS · 3. DETAILED TREATMENT · 4. INSTITUTIONAL AND REFORM ARCHITECTURE · 5. INDIAN APPLICATIONS AND BOUNDARY CASES · 6. LIMITATIONS AND TRADE-OFFS · 7. MUST-KNOW FACTS FOR ADVANCED PRELIMS

OPTIONAL ETHICAL DEPTH

- 1. Architecture
- 2. Concepts and distinctions
- 3. Detailed treatment
- 4. Institutional and reform architecture

ADVANCED LIMIT / TRADE-OFF

- 5. Indian applications and boundary cases
- 6. Limitations and trade-offs
- 7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims
- 8. Advanced Prelims traps

ADMINISTRATIVE APPLICATION

- 9. Current-anchor application
- 10. PYQ-based analytical application
- 11. Mains-ready framework
- 12. Probable questions

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels